Clout City: Hollywood Music — Game Concept Note

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This note explains what Clout City: Hollywood Music is, who it's for and how it plays. It is a sister game to Clout City: NYC and reuses most of its systems, screens and rules; this note says what carries over, what changes and what is new. Where it and a spec differ in detail, the spec wins (section 14).

1. The game

Clout City: Hollywood Music is a mobile-first, browser-based life game where you arrive in a fictional Hollywood as a nobody with an instrument and chase fame, from a café open mic to a sold-out stadium. It's Sims-style living crossed with a rhythm game and a serialized music tabloid. You rent a room, build a band, play shows as a tap-the-notes performance game, take brand deals, and climb the fame ladder, while a satirical daily story about the scene unfolds that the whole town follows together.

The fantasy: become the headliner. The welcome screen sets it up: "Welcome to Hollywood. Every waiter here is in a band. Yours just has to be the one that makes it."

The goal: reach Stadium Status. In P1 that means climbing from open mics to the neighborhood's biggest theater, growing a fanbase, and calling the twists in the scene's stories before everyone else. The stadium sits on the edge of the map from day one, lit up and locked, as the promise of where this ends.

Tagline: "PLAY LOUD. BLOW UP."

2. Who it's for

Core player: university students and early-career young adults who live online, follow music and celebrity drama, and have at least once believed they could be famous. They play casual life sims and rhythm games on their phones in short sessions, and binge serialized stories.

What they want from it: a playful rise-to-fame fantasy, a skill game that feels great under the thumbs, a reason to come back every day (tomorrow's beat, tonight's show), something to argue about with friends, and a world that's funny about chasing fame rather than earnest about it.

Where they are: the setting is Hollywood, but the game is built for players anywhere. As in Clout City: NYC, a fast city clock cycles day and night every couple of hours so nightlife and show times work in every time zone, while the real New York calendar keeps everyone on the same story beat on the same day.

Age: 18+, confirmed at sign-up, because of chat, real-money purchases and the scene's adult drama.

3. Design pillars

The six Clout City pillars carry over, with fame in place of clout and one new pillar for the performance game.

1. **The town follows the story together.** Everyone sees the same beat on the same day and finds out together.
2. **Satire with real mechanics.** A gossip narrator and petty music-industry stakes on top of real choices about rent, bandmates and which shows to take.
3. **Fame is the scoreboard, and the key.** Every system feeds fame. Unlike clout in NYC, fame also unlocks bigger venues: it's how you climb.
4. **Shows must feel great.** The performance game is the heart of the loop. Tight timing, readable notes and a crowd that reacts come before any other feature.
5. **Short sessions, daily return.** A song is about 2 minutes, a beat is a 10-second read, and something new waits every day.
6. **Real money is always marked, never a shortcut.** Real money is written $ with a gold border and the ✨ REAL CASH tag; virtual cash is C$ and can never be bought. Money never buys a better score, an easier song, a venue unlock or a guessing edge.

What it is not

- **Not a real map.** The town is one compact, hand-illustrated 2D map, not real streets.
- **Not a music library.** Every song is original or royalty-free. No real songs, artists, labels or venues.
- **Not pay-to-win.** No score boosts, no continues, no song skips, no buying fans.
- **Not a stranger-chat app.** Chat keeps Clout City's 10-a-day cap, filter, block, report and review queue.
- **Not grim.** The scene's drama (breakups, shady lawyers, an obsessive fan) stays satirical and off-screen where it's serious.

4. How it plays

The game works at three timescales: a first session that ends with your first show, a short daily session, and the long climb up the fame ladder.

First session (about 10 minutes)

1. Open a link and land on the Echo Flats map as a guest; pan around and see the stadium glowing, locked, on the edge of town.
2. Tap anything and sign up.
3. Create your artist in four steps: **Look** (name and avatar, as in Clout City), **Sound** (pick an instrument, one of eight starting scenes such as Garage Rocker or Bedroom Pop, and a band name), **Birth lottery** (roll starting cash), **Home** (choose a room in Echo Flats and move in).
4. A satirical welcome and a five-tooltip tour of fame, money, the map, the phone and shows.
5. **First task: open mic night.** The café's open mic is "happening now." You play one short song in the performance game, with a built-in tutorial. Whatever your score, you earn your first fans, fame and tips, and land on the leaderboard.
6. Invite friends, add the game to your home screen, and meet the scene's current story.

Daily session (5 to 15 minutes)

- Read today's story beat in the News app and vote in any open prediction.
- Play today's shows: each venue you've unlocked offers one paid show per day.
- Work through five daily tasks: shows, visits, practice, story tasks.
- Work a day job or take a brand deal for cash, eat to refill Energy, rehearse with your band, shop for gear and outfits.
- Pay rent and your band, check the leaderboard, message friends.

Long term: the fame ladder

Fame unlocks venues. Each tier is a bigger room, a harder version of the songs and a bigger payday.

Tier	Fame needed	Venue (Echo Flats)	Capacity	Difficulty	In P1
Nobody	0	The Grind café open mic	40	Open Mic: 3 lanes, taps and holds	Yes
Local Act	500	The Rusty Amp dive bar	120	Bar: 4 lanes	Yes

Tier	Fame needed	Venue (Echo Flats)	Capacity	Difficulty	In P1
Buzzing	2,500	The Basement club	400	Club: chords and power strums	Yes
Headliner	10,000	The Marquee theater	1,500	Theater: faster, crowd calls	Yes
Star	40,000	The Echo Bowl amphitheater (another district)	12,000	Arena	Later
Stadium Status	150,000	The Halo Dome stadium	60,000	Stadium	Later (visible, locked)

Thresholds, capacities and pay live in config. Along the way players grow a fanbase, hire and keep bandmates, upgrade their room and gear, follow each weekly story to its finale, and collect hunt cards, postcards and badges.

5. The world

P1 is one neighborhood, Echo Flats, on a compact hand-illustrated map of a fictional Hollywood, in the style of Lagos Life rather than Clout City's real-street map of Queens.

- **One contained map, not real geography.** The whole town is a single illustrated board you can see almost entirely at one zoom: chunky buildings drawn as illustrated sprites, palm-lined roads, hills, and day and night versions. It's a stylized Hollywood that players recognize by its signs and silhouettes, not its street grid.
- **Echo Flats first.** A scrappy, artsy neighborhood of rented rooms, cafés, dive bars and one great old theater, about 16 places close together so trips are short and cheap.
- **The rest of town is locked.** Around Echo Flats sit districts shown under drifting clouds with "Locked: Coming soon": Starline Boulevard (walk of stars and theaters), Neon Row (the club strip), Canyon Heights (mansions), the Studio Lot (labels and studios) and the Pier District. The Halo Dome stadium sits on its own lot at the far edge, always lit, always visible: the goal.
- **The hillside sign.** Above the town, giant white letters on the hill spell CLOUTWOOD. It's the game's own landmark (never the real sign or its lettering), a monument players can visit, pose at and collect as a postcard.
- **Places** follow Clout City's rules: each has a card with an illustration, lore and actions, a price and a reward, a once-a-day fame cooldown, and can be changed by stories. Performance venues add show slots; dining restores Energy in three tiers.
- **People:** a recurring cast of invented music-scene characters (a shady entertainment lawyer, a club booker, a band that keeps almost breaking up) and NPCs who gossip about the current story. The narrator is Lola Lowdown, who has moved west:

"Hollywood's most reliable unreliable source."

- **Two clocks,** unchanged from Clout City: a fast city clock (a day every 2 hours) for day, night and show times, and the real New York calendar for stories, resets, bills and anything that pays out.
- **Look and feel:** Hollywood after dark: dark glass over a sunset-to-night map, marquee lights, neon, red main buttons, spotlight-yellow accents and gold kept for marking real money (Design System Guide).

6. Shows: the performance game

Every show is a short rhythm game played on a note highway, built from the mechanics in the reference videos and redesigned for thumbs on a phone. Full rules are in Clarifications section 5; the screen is in the Design System Guide.

What we take from each reference (mechanics only, never their look, names or songs)

Reference	Mechanic we use	How it adapts to mobile
Guitar Hero (fret highway)	Notes scroll down lanes to a hit line; sustains, chords, streak multiplier, a power meter you trigger, a crowd meter that can boo you off	4 thumb lanes (3 at open mics) instead of 5 frets; tap, hold and two-lane chords
DJ Hero (3-lane turntable)	Few, wide lanes; scratch notes; hit-streak callouts	Scratches become swipe notes ("power strums"); the DJ instrument and crossfades come later
PaRappa the Rapper (call and response)	A teacher plays a phrase, you repeat it; a live rating that rises and falls	"Crowd call" sections in harder songs, and the bandmate rehearsal mini-game at the studio

How a show plays

1. Pick a song from your setlist at a venue you've unlocked; the venue sets the difficulty.
2. Notes slide down the lanes; tap, hold or swipe as each crosses the hit line. Timing grades are Perfect, Great, Good or Miss.
3. Hit streaks raise your multiplier (up to ×4). Glowing **Hype** phrases fill the Hype meter; trigger it to double the multiplier while the stage lights go wild.
4. The **Crowd meter** reads the room live (Losing It, Into It, Restless, Booing). Empty it and you're booed off: the show ends early with partial pay and a Lola roast.

5. At the end: a star rating (1 to 5), accuracy, best streak, fans gained, fame and cash.

Songs. P1 ships 6 original songs (about 2 minutes each), each charted at the four P1 difficulties: for example "Rent's Due (Again)," "Opening Act Forever" and "My Ex Started a Podcast." Story beats can add a limited-time song (a diss track, a breakup ballad).

Fair by design. Practice is free and unlimited at home. Gear and outfits never change timing or scoring. Real money can never buy a continue, a skip, an easier chart or extra Hype.

7. Band, fame and fans

- **Fame** is the score (a star in the HUD, where NYC had the clout flame). It feeds the leaderboard and unlocks venue tiers.
- **Fans** are your audience, shown on your profile. Shows add fans by venue size and star rating; fans raise your door share and qualify you for brand deals.
- **The band.** You start solo. From Local Act on, you can hire up to three NPC bandmates (drums, bass, keys) from the Musicians Wanted board. Each has a one-line personality, a weekly fee and **Chemistry** (0 to 100). Rehearsals and good shows raise it; missed pay and bad shows lower it. Below 20, a bandmate may quit, which becomes news. The Basement and up need at least two bandmates.
- **Stats:** Energy, Mood and Confidence, as in Clout City. Shows, visits and work spend Energy; meals restore it; Mood and Confidence scale fame gains.

8. Systems at a glance

Every P1 system, where it comes from, and which spec owns it.

System	What it does	From Clout City	Owning spec
Fame and leaderboard	Score in the HUD; unlocks venue tiers	Reused (clout renamed); now gates venues	Clarifications
Shows (performance game)	Rhythm game at venues; pays fans, fame, cash	New	Clarifications, Design Guide
Fans	Audience size; door share and brand-deal gate	New	Clarifications

System	What it does	From Clout City	Owning spec
Band and Chemistry	Hire, pay, rehearse and keep up to 3 bandmates	New	Clarifications
Bank balance (C$)	Virtual cash; never bought	Reused	Clarifications
Net worth and Net Worth screen	Cash plus items; sell at 60%	Reused	Clarifications
Stats	Energy, Mood, Confidence	Reused	Clarifications
Daily tasks, goals, hunts	Five tasks a day; weekly hunt per starting scene	Reused, re-themed	Clarifications, New Features Spec
Places	Cards, lore, actions, cooldowns, dining tiers	Reused, Echo Flats set	Clarifications
Day jobs and brand deals	Shifts for cash; deals in three tiers gated by fans	Reused (gigs re-themed)	Clarifications
Events	Club nights (C$), free story events, exclusive events (real money)	Reused	Clarifications
Shop	Fashion, Instruments, Gear, Rides, Homes, Luxury	Reused plus music categories	Clarifications
Bills	Weekly rent, phone, band pay	Reused plus band pay	Clarifications
Stories	Daily beats, predictions, world effects, side arcs	Reused	World State, Story Quality briefs
Crew, chat, crushes	Invites, 10-a-day chat, date nights	Reused	Clarifications
UI	Every screen and component	Reused plus performance components	Design Guide

9. Money

The same four real-money products as Clout City, one-time Stripe Checkout payments, no premium currency.

Product	Hollywood version	Fame
Exclusive events	Listening parties, award-show afterparties, a superstar's secret show	Yes, diminishing returns
Story side arcs	$2.99 each: perspective, evidence or insider takes	None
Collector items	A few rare instruments and stage outfits, found in the Shop, never promoted	Yes, diminishing returns
Monument postcards	$0.99 each, after visiting (the CLOUTWOOD sign, the Wall of Almost)	None

Rules that don't bend: C$ can never be bought; real money is always marked; money never affects the performance game, venue unlocks, fans or predictions; a refund revokes the purchase and its fame. Songs are never sold in P1.

10. Stories

Stories work exactly as in Clout City: serialized, satirical, shared by the whole town, delivered through the World State layer. What changes is the drama, which follows the life of a rising music star.

- **Format:** 6 to 10 beats, one per real day, read in the News app, each ending on a cliffhanger, narrated by Lola Lowdown.
- **Play, not just read:** 2 to 3 predictions per story, story tasks (go to a venue, play the story song, open an evidence card), NPC gossip, and visible changes to the town: a show cancelled, a club packed with fans, a diss track added to every setlist for a week.
- **The drama:** early-career struggle, band breakups, dating drama, shady lawyers and predatory contracts, cancelled shows, an obsessive superfan, sudden viral fame and its backlash. Serious subjects stay off-screen and satirical (Story Quality Brief).
- **Fair to free players:** every mystery is solvable for free; $2.99 side arcs add perspective, evidence and insider color but never help anyone guess.
- **First story:** "Who Cancelled the Midnight Saints?", a 10-day Echo Flats mystery: the neighborhood's hottest band has its Marquee headline show cancelled the night before a label exec comes to sign them. A lighter dating comedy follows, and Lola writes a weekly dating column. After the pilot, a new story starts every Sunday.

11. Social and growth

Reused from Clout City almost unchanged.

- **The crew:** each friend who signs up pays fame to the inviter; a crew of five earns a big bonus. A friend can be brought to your first open mic as your "plus-one in the crowd."
- **Shared talk:** live poll results, the reveal card, and a shareable show result card ("4 stars at The Rusty Amp. 37 new fans.").
- **Leaderboard:** fame for Echo Flats and your crew; profiles show fame, rank, fans and net worth publicly.
- **Chat, crushes and date nights:** as in Clout City, with one addition: a date night can be "come to my show," where your date attends a venue the same day you play it.
- **Return triggers:** the daily beat, the daily task reset, today's show slots, prediction close times, and rent and band pay coming due.

12. Success metrics

Headline: first show completed; crew invite sent; day-1 return of 35 to 40% (stretch goal: 50%).

Performance health: shows per player per day, songs finished versus booed off, average stars by difficulty, practice sessions, and drop-off at each venue tier.

Story and money: beat opens, prediction participation, side-arc and exclusive-event purchases, return rate during an arc.

13. Roadmap and decisions

Everything below is after P1 and must not be built now.

Area	Later ideas
Districts	Starline Boulevard, Neon Row, Canyon Heights, the Studio Lot, the Pier District; the Echo Bowl amphitheater and the Halo Dome stadium
Instruments	DJ (turntable lanes, scratches, crossfades), Vocals (call-and-response), Drums
Music career	Record and release singles, daily streaming royalties, music videos, tours, a record label deal, an agent

Area	Later ideas
Social	Player bands (friends as bandmates), battle of the bands, co-op shows, players in the same crowd
Content	New song packs (earned, never sold), seasonal events (award season, festival weekend)
Money	A seasonal pass, purchases at venues (merch tables)

Decided for P1: 18+; one neighborhood (Echo Flats) with about 16 places; four performance venues and six original songs, the first four made with an AI music tool; fame gates venues; fans gate brand deals; Guitar and Keys are the P1 instruments, sharing one chart format; NPC bandmates only; stack Next.js, Supabase, Stripe and Vercel, as in Clout City, with the Web Audio API for the performance game.

14. Document map and precedence

Read this note first, then the document that owns the area you're working on. Each Hollywood Music document is a delta on its Clout City counterpart, so keep the Clout City docs in the repo for reference. When two documents disagree, the owner below wins; flag the disagreement rather than choosing silently.

Document	Owns	Read it for
Game Concept Note (this)	The why and the big picture	Orientation, the fame ladder, roadmap, decisions
Clarifications & Updates	Game rules and P1 scope	Onboarding, HUD, places, the performance game, band, economy, events
World State Layer Brief	Engine behavior	Arcs, effects (including show slots and story songs), predictions, entitlements
Design System Guide	UI	Token changes, the illustrated map, the show screen, components C46 to C65
Story Quality Brief	Content rules	Writing and checking every story; the pilot blueprint
Milestones and Versions	What ships when	Versions v0.1 to v1.0, song and place rollout

Document	Owns	Read it for
New Features Spec	Supporting features	Hunts, Story Studio, News, cast and NPCs, the AI song pipeline, later features